

TSANGAI BUSINESS GROWTH SERIES · #09

The Client Onboarding Playbook

Turn "you're hired" into a wow moment — a welcome system that impresses every new client in the first 48 hours, set up today.

WHO IT'S FOR

Service businesses where every new client starts from a blank email

TIME REQUIRED

15 minutes

WHAT YOU'LL ACHIEVE

A welcome email, intake form, and kickoff checklist — ready before your next client says yes

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Clients decide if they trust you in the first 48 hours — not the first 90 days.

This playbook gives you a three-piece onboarding system: a welcome email, an intake form, and a kickoff checklist. AI drafts all three today; your next client feels the difference immediately.

Buyer's remorse starts the moment the invoice is paid and the silence begins. A great onboarding kills it dead: the client hears from you within an hour, knows exactly what happens next, and thinks "these people have their act together." That impression sets the tone for every renewal, referral, and review that follows.

— Ray, TsangAI Consulting

WHY THIS MATTERS

48 hrs

The window where a new client decides they made the right call — or starts doubting

3 pieces

Welcome email, intake form, kickoff checklist — that's the whole system

1st week

Referrals are most likely when excitement peaks — right after a great start

THE ONE IDEA

Onboarding is a system, not a vibe.

Winging it works when you're not busy. But the busier you get, the worse your onboarding gets — exactly when you can least afford it. A written sequence means every client gets your best first week, even during your worst one.

Example: A marketing agency sent proposals fast but went quiet after signing. New system: welcome email within the hour, intake form same day, kickoff booked within 48 hours. Their next client's first message: "Wow — that was the smoothest start we've ever had."

YOUR 10-MINUTE QUICK WIN

- ☐ Copy the Welcome Email template from page 4 and fill in your details
- ☐ Save it where you send email (draft, snippet, or template)
- ☐ List your 5 intake questions using the starter list on page 4
- ☐ Next signed client: send the welcome within one hour and watch the reply

Five steps to a 48-hour wow

1 Map what happens today

Write the real sequence between "yes" and "work starts" — every email, call, and awkward gap. The gaps are where trust leaks.

Do this: List your current steps on paper. Mark every spot where the client waits with no update.

2 Set up the welcome email

Sent within one hour of signing. It confirms the decision, names the next step, and tells them exactly what happens when. Template on page 4.

Do this: Personalize the template once, save it as a reusable draft or snippet.

3 Build the intake form

One form that gathers everything you normally chase across six emails: access, contacts, goals, deadlines, preferences. Five to ten questions max.

Do this: Use the AI prompt on page 4 to generate your questions, then build it in Google Forms or your CRM.

4 Create the kickoff checklist

Everything that must be true before work starts: form back, kickoff call booked, expectations confirmed, first milestone dated. Same list, every client.

Do this: Write the checklist (steal the starter on page 4) and store it with your SOPs.

5 Automate the triggers

Connect the dots so the sequence runs itself: contract signed → welcome email → intake form → reminder if not completed → kickoff booking link. Zapier, n8n, or your CRM can do this in an afternoon.

Do this: Automate just the first trigger this week: signed → welcome email sends itself.

COMMON MISTAKES

This is where most business owners get stuck.

They celebrate the sale and go quiet for a week. They ask for information in dribbles across ten emails instead of one form. And they make the first impression depend on how busy their inbox is that day.

PRO TIP

Add one unexpected touch to the first 48 hours — a 60-second personal welcome video, a small gift, or a "here's your team" photo. It costs almost nothing, and it's the thing clients mention when they refer you.

The welcome email, intake questions, and kickoff checklist

The Welcome Email Template

Subject: Welcome aboard, **[FIRST NAME]** – here's what happens next

Hi **[FIRST NAME]**,

Great decision – we're excited to get started on **[PROJECT / SERVICE]**.

Here's exactly what happens next:

1. Today: you'll get a short intake form (takes ~5 minutes).
2. Within 48 hours: we'll book your kickoff call – grab a time here: **[BOOKING LINK]**.
3. By **[DATE]**: **[FIRST MILESTONE]**.

Questions anytime – just reply to this email. Talk soon,
[YOUR NAME]

Intake Questions (pick 5–10)

- ✓ What does a home-run result look like in 90 days?
- ✓ Who is our day-to-day contact, and how do they prefer updates?
- ✓ What deadlines or events should we plan around?
- ✓ What logins/access will we need? (list them)
- ✓ What did you like — and not like — about past providers?
- ✓ Anything that would make this feel like a great experience?

Kickoff Checklist

- ☐ Welcome email sent within 1 hour of signing
- ☐ Intake form completed and reviewed
- ☐ Kickoff call booked within 48 hours
- ☐ Scope + first milestone confirmed in writing
- ☐ Client added to updates channel / schedule

The Onboarding Builder Prompt

You are a client experience consultant for service businesses. My business: **[WHAT YOU DO]** for **[WHO]**. A typical project: **[BRIEF DESCRIPTION]**. Build my onboarding kit: 1) a warm welcome email under 150 words with a clear "what happens next" list, 2) the 8 best intake form questions for my service, 3) a kickoff call agenda for 30 minutes, 4) a check-in message for day 7. Match this tone: **[FRIENDLY / PROFESSIONAL]**.

MAKE IT YOURS

Run the prompt, then read everything out loud once. Anything you wouldn't actually say, rewrite in your own words. The system should sound like you on your best day.

Turn this guide into one win this week.

A guide you read changes nothing. A page you fill in does. Two minutes — do it while it's fresh.

1 • WHERE I AM TODAY

Ready: welcome email ☐ intake form ☐ kickoff checklist ☐

2 • THE ONE THING I'M FIXING THIS WEEK

My one fix: _____

The first small step (under 15 minutes): _____

Small beats big. Pick something you can finish in one sitting.

3 • WHEN I'M DOING IT

Day: _____ Time: _____ Booked in my calendar? ☐

Open your calendar and book it now — a plan without a time slot is a wish.

4 • AFTER — WHAT HAPPENED

My result (hours saved, jobs booked, thing shipped): _____

What I'll do differently next time: _____

NOTES

KEEP THE STREAK

One fix a week is 52 upgrades a year. When this page is full, re-take the guide — a rising score is proof your systems are working.